

Medellin to Combat Sex Tourism by Regulating Short-Term Rentals

By **Victor Cohen** March 14, 2024



Medellin Mayor Federico Gutierrez is considering new regulations on short-term rentals like Airbnb to combat sex tourism and sex exploitation. Credit : Victor Cohen/ColombiaOne

As sex tourism emerges as a significant concern in Medellin, Mayor Federico Gutierrez has expressed his intention to regulate short-term rentals in the city. Platforms like Airbnb, which have revolutionized the short-stay market globally, have been pointed out for being utilized by sex tourists and sexual predators.

Legislation already exists in Medellin to control the rental and hotels market. Therefore, the proposed regulations will specifically address the exploitation of these services for sexual purposes.

Short-term rentals in Medellin

As of December 2023, 75 percent of Medellin's 5,900 vacation lodgings were touristic apartments. Despite existing regulations for these accommodations, enforcement is lacking, with many operating illegally or without proper registration. As such, the Medellin Mayor's Office reports that approximately 1,700 housing units are offering services without the necessary paperwork.

The surge in tourism has led to a boom in short-term rental platforms like Airbnb, with many apartment buildings being constructed with the exclusive goal to offer short-term rentals, exacerbating the problem.

However, while one of the consequences is a global surge in real estate and renting prices in the city, the primary concern highlighted by Mayor Federico Gutierrez's statements is the issue of sex tourism and the sexual exploitation of minors.

Short-term rentals and sex tourism in Medellin



In 2024, three foreign nationals, two Americans and one Canadian, were arrested in Medellin on charges related to sexual exploitation, with the Canadian also facing murder charges.

These individuals were utilizing short-term rental apartments to carry out their crimes, highlighting a significant issue with such accommodations. Specifically, the lack of control over the legal status of clients and the identities of their guests, especially when underaged.

In response to these events, Mayor Federico Gutierrez announced that the city is considering a ban on “the use of apartments or houses for short-term rental dedicated to sexual exploitation and prostitution”. While specific measures to enhance control are yet to be announced, they will fall under the jurisdiction of Medellin’s newly established Secretary of Tourism and Entertainment.

Tourism plays a vital role in Medellin’s economy, contributing to 7 percent of its GDP and generating 110,000 direct and indirect jobs. While it represents a spectacular opportunity for the city’s growth and development, it necessitates regulation to prevent criminal activities. As such, sex tourism has emerged as a pressing concern, drawing attention at the highest levels of the Colombian government, as illustrated by [VP Francia Marquez recent statements](#) on the issue.

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